

Preoccupied
RENJ

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Foreword

There are some people you leave behind.

There are others you carry with you without meaning to.

I used to think that forgetting was the opposite of remembering. I thought that if I could stop saying someone's name, stop visiting the places where we had been, stop turning ordinary things into evidence of something that happened before, then eventually the story would become what it was supposed to be: *finished*.

It never did.

Preoccupied is about that failure.

It is about love when it becomes memory, and memory when it becomes accusation. It is about the strange violence of making a home out of another person, only to discover that the house remains standing after they leave. It is about the things I wanted, the things I was given, and the things I convinced myself I had been denied.

Some of these poems remember tenderness.

Some remember cruelty.

Some remember neither particularly well.

I have learned that memory is a terrible witness. It rearranges rooms. It changes names. It makes a stranger out of someone you once knew by touch. Sometimes it protects you; sometimes it incriminates you.

And perhaps that is why I am still writing about it.

Not because I want them back.

Not because I want the past to change.

But because there are absences that become so familiar that they begin to occupy more space than the person ever did.

This is a collection about that occupation.

About what remains when someone is gone—
and why, despite everything,
I am still *preoccupied*.

- RENJ

Lavender

RENJ

I take my own corner of the room and of my eyes;
There I see you, folding out in your pink tie.
You think it's funny how I usher blue in everywhere,
But troubled, you would never leave me without the azure.
Some days, I find it gross.

You wrap your hands and my belt holes come into contact,
And I talk about you in a crowd and your name's a redact.
And even if you knew, I know not to get in the way
Of the lavender harvest, the purplest of the day.

A year passes, your rose shawl is behind clear glass,
My sky fedoras all line up on the drying grass.
You warm my face, now all up to my brow is a pink ash,
And I touch you, the waves come ever to let us pass;
All days, I love how it goes.

You light the door when I come home bringing tickets,
I hold your hand and scrape off the rust on the locket.
And even if we knew how wrong we could be,
Our field's all lavender, as it should be.

You Your Subpoena

RENJ

You can't ask the reality of me
When I gave you my whole world.
You ask yourself to be free
So you could have someone in your own world.
You call about what you like,
And it's always the better guy.
You call about what you dislike,
And it's the chains I always buy.

I don't even long for what we had,
I just want to know the motives that you had.
But I won't mail you your subpoena:
Even with the thought of you, I've had enough.

You cry my name in your sleep,
And I color my whole world.
And then mouth that we're just too deep,
Then now I'll wonder why it became my world.
Because when you become,
My whole house is pulled undone.
You ask about the years to come;
Now my whole study is bygone.

I don't even long for what we had,
I just wanna know why the evil didn't feel so bad.
But I won't give you a piece of my mind
When I know you have yours left behind.

And I hear from certain someones
You have always wanted me gone.
And I wonder why you told everyone
About our scorpion-laden bed
And my so-called endless dread,
When all I did was to keep you fed.
And they ask for forgiveness
For their unpromptedness,
A single sorry, one you can never digress.
Maybe one day, you'll tell me,
And I'll rejoice that I've been free;
You'll offer your roses, I'm no honeybee.

A Wonderful Lifetime

RENJ

In your phone, I'm a call like golden honey,
Sticky sweet, amber lips like heirloom money.
I believe in the thoughts that you place me on;
I resist the pedestal that you insist I'm on.
I'll be on your back like a halo on a saint's head,
And I'll be your devotee until both of my knees bleed.

Oh, what a wonderful lifetime,
To be stuck in your bed, keep to ourselves our crime.
I would do anything to keep you off the climb,
And choose the perfect altar to keep it divine.
The land, the sky, the in-between, they all collide
To make a wonderful lifetime.

On your nightstand, I'm a lamp flickering in melody,
Like a book on your bed reciting a tragedy.
I guess you should believe the diamond off my body:
Salty sweet, liquefied, a truce of my insantity.
When the trysts turn to vows and incapacity,
To hold on to hope, so we make it a reality.

Oh, what a wonderful lifetime:
Singing through your songs, writing until it subsides.
I would do everything to coax my pride,
But in a gluttonous unrest, the humility's all I abide.
The palms, the bends, all the thoughts in between, all collide
To make a wonderful lifetime.

In your concert, I'll be chasing your holy riffs;
I am no farmer, but I'd keep to sow until I reap.
Sometimes, I wonder if it would last until the sunset,
Grateful I am that every new day is just a reset.
So I turn to bow on your behalf on a half-naked stage,
And the red curtains on my back turn into a golden age.

Oh, what a wonderful lifetime,
Being in the crowd, chosen to live a life people long to find.
They all ask about the conscience of my mind,
And inquire about my existence, if I'm bona fide.
The tears, the laughs, everything they throw in, all collide
To make a wonderful lifetime.

Years Undercover

RENJ

Oh, darling, you know who I'm going to—
Years undercover, wishing just for you.

Months longing in the shadows for some light,
Silent prayers in the loudest dinners.
She was with her father in her sleep;
I watch your headshots through the night,
Scraped my hair until it got thinner,
Because maybe I'll meet you in my sleep.

Oh, darling, you know who I'm going to—
Years undercover, wishing just for you.

Barren conversations over big words:
They cry morals, I cry desperation.
Unspoken speeches delivered on Sunday pews
A summer in a scorching world.
I take my companion's condescension;
She was a title, you were the lines in every few.

Oh, darling, you know who I'm going to—
Years undercover, wishing just for you.

Suffered in my voluntary matrimony,
My ashes scattered on my wedding day.
Now that I'm dead and long gone,
She and I are now just another memory.
I long to finally hold you under the day;
It has been a long time, I'm long undone.

Oh, darling, you know who I'm going to—
Years undercover, wishing just for you.

Silent onlookers with loudest throats will
Throw us under their bubbling curves.
But I have written in the hour under the Sun
Wishes that have finally done into my will.
Now that I get to say the name stuck on my nerves,
I will never forsake your name again.

Oh, darling, you know who I'm going to—
Years undercover, wishing just for you.

Gave In

RENJ

Came and went the night I always looked forward to;
A day creeps in, and the light makes it a coward.
I wake with my thighs deep into yours,
And I ask about the errors that led into this force.
The vinyl won't play itself if only hung on the wall;
The telephones will turn into rust if no one calls.

And I recall you were the one I was dancing with,
Even when the lights went out and our friends waved.
Your eyes split like almonds, my mouth cracked like a can;
All those numbers on my burner end up, and so we began.

Parties and party people came to crash into our midnights—
How on earth did the tractor enter my flat?
I scream my thoughts into the crowd, but the music fades in;
I trust the motions of my iris, but in our world, you're in.
Another morning is waiting, you're a bird on the bottle chasing,
And somehow it doesn't matter now, the songs we chose to sing.

And I recall the records that slipped in between:
The plates crumple in the heat, derived from the cold within.
Your arms like a flagpole, and our promise that was an oath
Got to become international, it was perused.

I wake into memories, into fantasies—what a strange way to give in.
I wake into cavities, into alimonies—what a strange way to cave in.
I wake in your fantasies, in our crowded seas—how I wish we gave in.
I wake in your cavity, and our crowd-dead deed—how I wish we gave in.

How Mystical It Is to Me

RENJ

Static occupied the radio when I was five,
Listening to the worst-performing songs,
Playing in the night where no one gives any thought.
You were six when you punched a beehive,
Swore that the whole thing was two feet long,
Singing my song like you gave it some thought.

Years, long-withered fears come wrap the reddish sky:
An eclipse, and a plane that refused to fly.
Oh, how mystical it is to me,
That some sort of force brought you to me.

I was at my grandma's house when I turned fifteen,
I was crying over cliché webcomic novels.
You were picking gold over red for your head that time,
Now I wonder if you knew my favorite hour by then.
They say it's sinister for all the stars to revel,
But I just think it's the wondrous time.

Years, long-withered tears end the farce in the sky:
Something blue, something green failed to fly.
Oh, how mystical it is to me,
That some sort of happenstance led you to me.

Some years came over and then you settled in,
The crying children in me are all coaxed into the nursery.
Failing demons were brave enough to become angels;
Your blessings and favorite clothes are in my walk-in,
The rules of roadside parking are but a memory—
Oh, what a wonderful way I took to meet a stranger.

Years, long-withered glares calm the unhopeful tide.
Were there pieces that fell into place that hide?
Oh, how mystical it is to me,
That some sort of coincidence gave you to me.

Don't Worry

RENJ

There are certain things I swear I could like again,
Like a cinephile, his favorite books, and favorite tropes.
All his friends go quiet, as the movie is about to begin;
He couldn't shut up about the clichés hidden in blind hope.

He would curate his own habits, ask if it looked as nice
As his ideation of a perfect film—I admit he looked nice.

Don't worry, I'll never hang with him again;
He says what a great director he could've been.
But I would say: what a world-class show—
Shame, it's a performance I know.

There are better things that should be eloped,
Like thoughts of death and love can mix it up;
But his eyes stayed red as he slid down the slope,
And his movies are my reality I could not give up.

He would kiss my forehead when we were in private;
I admit it looked awkward when we had to be a secret.

He said, "Don't worry, one day, they'll want us."
I was holding on a failing house's overwater truss.
But I would say: I did hope that he would come around—
Shame, it's the only thing I've known about.

I had a good time with him, but I'll see it again
When it's over and I could trust myself not to begin:
The clandestinous loudness of a secret,
And a pledge I wrote when I hoped I'd see him in my arrest.
I hope my pillow was cold on both sides,
In case he was with me on my backside.
But I guess I should've known when I first saw him:
A script on the table, and I refused to listen to them.
Guess I'll never know what he said on the phone
When he called my professions a scandalous moan.

I sit on the couch watching his favorite movies back,
Trying to rewind so I could see him in between the tracks.
And the frame rate was screwed, so I spun myself again;
Guess I'll forever be your favorite card on the helm.

The Walk Home

RENJ

Walked my way home so I could think more,
Mind on its own, my thighs can't take it anymore.
So I rested by the road to pass the time.
See some old couple run into an old door,
So I stand up and look what it's for,
And I blink: there were portraits across time.

I couldn't erase the oil painting in my mind:
A prince and princess running wild.
And so in my curtains, I see your hair,
Then I pretend to caress it from behind,
Like an old story about a forbidden child;
Then I blink, I come back to the modern air.

I couldn't erase the crying lady on the wall,
And in my mind she's better and well.
The description said her husband's off for war,
And I wonder if you would cry at all.
I think you'll call my name every day down the wishing well;
Then I blink, I come back to the modern fair.

I didn't know there was even a museum here;
I have been walking this road for years.
And so my instincts turn on, called you up,
Said we could spend some time here.
The old couple smiled from ear to ear;
Then I blink, I'm on my way home again.

Your Favorite Shirt

RENJ

You left your favorite shirt on my bus seat,
I call your name as you fade from the backseat,
I offer my condolences,
Because this might be the last day I see you.

But I get awoken by the dead,
Reliving the mites on your bed.
I've turned televisions until they come undone,
Now we both know what is gone.

And I will hold on to your sleeves,
And we'll pretend last times are not real.
We only turn to laugh at ourselves,
You're no queen of court, I am nothing real.
People throw bills at us because they love the show,
And it will be tricks on our sleeves.

You broke into my house through the window,
I crash your car, but not enough to make a widow,
I offer my regressive nights,
Because this might be the last time I see you.

But I drive on highways on your head,
You drive me insane when I become your dread.
I've turned curbs into apartments until they crumble down,
We chose to retread us down.

And I will hold on to your knees,
And you'll be on your own until you bleed.
We get lost finding perfect Christmas trees,
You're quite the narcissist, I am quite the knucklehead,
People throw us under the bus because we're bungees,
And it will be on our knees.

There are days on my seat when I just laugh,
Funny how I found our arrangement comedy.
Sometimes, I wonder to myself what will be ever enough,
But you told yourself, when it ends, it will be a tragedy.
Until one time, I put the ring I bought into my finger,
And the stone at the top felt a little heavier.
You watched me trying it on and your gaze lingers,
As if a suspended silence makes it lovelier.
And who's gonna wear this, if not me?

You left your favorite shirt on my bus seat,
This will be the last time you'll fade from the backseat.

Preoccupied

RENJ

I remember the tables, two chairs for one.
It was in a mall's food court, coupons bygone.
I watch real couples eat until they're done;
The Coke in the can waits until I hold your hand.

Two kids approach and their mother apologizes;
She says she's sorry for bothering our date.
I laughed it all off because I wish it realizes,
But I'm leaving at the terminal and you'll be at your gate.

Yet you refused the steps onto the tracks;
You said you came to your senses, so you ran back.
What have I ever done to deserve your presence?
The day is preoccupied, it's afraid of your absence.

Two months go down with the monsoon;
The east winds go crazy as the spinning moon.
You'll call what we have love anytime soon;
It would be an oasis in an endless summertime dune.

I breathe your father's nightmares and his occupation,
Trying to fit in like some kind of alien occasion.
Somehow I felt like I'm in a cornfield abduction –
The highs and the lows capture the least of my emotions.

Yet you refused to not step on the cracks;
You said I should come to my senses, so I had to go back.
You grieve for my numbness, I grieve your presence;
Guess I'm forever preoccupied with your absence.

Running horses feed on well-kept grass on the mountains;
One kick and they'll push you to be born again.
My neck is a substance, my throat is a bargain;
The colors of their hairs are the colors of how we began.

Three months of burning gas on the reserves;
Sometimes, I ask, if this is all that I deserve.
I can show you colors, but a prism is not a curve,
So I'd keep my lambs out and put a lane on my herd.

Because I refuse to live inside the pavement crack,
Glimmers of sunlight, and lots of wishing to go back.
And I'm sorry if you suffocate me with your mere presence;
I'll be preoccupied, so you better get ready for your absence.

What Is a Happenstance

RENJ

Was I too kind at the beginning of the year?
They say dysfunction is a manifestation of karma,
But God, is it suffocating to be good and here,
Abandoning pendulums just to force a summer.

They say there are few friends that you only need,
But how wide was the secret society you formed,
That when I came back on my own creed,
They knew better than I will ever be informed.

Deep breaths, long lines, near my final destination—
None I muttered because of your timely dispensation.
You can't hold me by the neck and ask to kiss yours,
Or tie my hands and guilt me for not holding yours.
Some pavements hold better with big feelings;
Maybe my passive eyes had you pacing and reeling.
Such strong coincidences held on by chance:
When too much, what is a happenstance?

Across islands and across narrow channels,
People longing for eyes of the unbeaten.
Yet I cross your mind like lines on flannel;
Shame, I offered my eyes to the unwritten.

Patience is such a virtue, I admitted in an asylum.
Knowing too much for now, and nothing after,
And our brightest days are just glimmers of my gloom,
And your eternal fantasies are the only ones you're after.

Deep breaths and shaky hands on the steering wheel,
I won't give you the satisfaction of ending it for the well.
A strategic duplication of assets and being afar,
Somehow, being one foot out wasn't a sin to spar.
You can wear neon rings and perform dash-and-dines,
But you would chase my fantasies for warning signs.
Guess I put too many hopes for reverence—
When too much, what is a happenstance?

Looking at a Daydream

RENJ

All my lovers are too clean and deep seas;
Tried to understand them, learning I can't swim.
So many speeches torn into burning pieces—
Hard to recover, but to me, it's no dream.
So many truths and oaths to keep from disease,
Better to track lies and fix them at the seams.

Somehow a castle was built over the mountaintop;
The rays of sun felt like rain that wouldn't stop,
But today's another day for me to stop.

Looking at a daydream and wish they were nightmares,
Think of colonizers, think of pirates to kill me seafarers.
I could be a Woodstock, I could be a flashlight glare.
And I do wish and wonder: is this for better?

All my drugs are kept hidden in perfect rows,
All pushed in bottles, forced to stand up for a master.
But now they're not brown, they all look like deep rose.
Used to be blind devotion, now my reflection is flatter.
Maybe I kept my word too tight for a compass rose;
Perhaps this is a thought that's finally healthy and matters.

Somehow a museum ran out of art;
A tower in Romania pulled a group of beating hearts.
Perhaps today is another day to start.

Looking at a daydream and wish they were real,
For the first time in months, I don't resent how I feel.
I thought it would be decades before I could close the deal,
And I do wish and wonder if my hands are enough to till.

Show Me Something Real

RENJ

Penny-worth perfumes, smoke into my clothes.
It's an irritating allergen, but a smell we both know.
It's an abandoned fort while the rain showers on:
Frail friars on the stand and the lights were left on.

I adored you, and how much you kept your change;
I despise you, for how slow we had to change.

Most nights can be too heavy for me,
But I trust our bed, that it'll lift me up for the night.
The leaves have turned old, the flowers past their bloom—
Loving is a romantic's ultimate doom.

I have loved you, and the way you held your hair tight;
I should hate you, and how your hands were too tight.

Show me something real and I would move on past,
I have shown myself a favorite couple, until it turned to gas.
I have brought my heart, and you have taken over my time—
I know it's biblically sacrificial, then I got agnostic in time.

It's too dry for a tear and a cheekbone;
All the plans, the plants, we tried to tailbone.
I don't want to get up anymore.

My feet stuck in a bark so hollow,
Pulling off the roots, as if the leaves would follow.
I don't want to get up anymore.

Show me something real and I would put it in the past,
But oh, I see the movements of time that'll never pass.

Harassed by Aghast

RENJ

Summer breeze colonizes our bedroom,
Tongues suspended in the nightstand's fume,
Kept into secrets, folded into heirlooms.
And I wonder sometimes if you can zoom,
See the bumps on my face in the restroom.

You don't own a car, but you drive down the block;
I call you my baby, you call me good luck.
Bins are best for disposal, but we're a pile at the back.
Run around the neighborhood 'til the hounds attack—
Long gone, never forgotten, we would always go back.

So I just wonder how long this will last,
How many tomorrows 'til you're part of the past.
They say it's evil to wonder about the moments of last,
But sometimes it gets me when you drive too fast.

The retail is open the whole week, the whole day;
You pity the owner, I pity the cashier's dismay.
Convenience is the trick of the constant delay,
But in your warehouse, I steal jackets from the crates.
I can sigh for a lifetime, but I could only breathe today.

Soon enough, your monsters will chase my witches,
And we'll be enveloped in constant baits and switches,
Our tongues at disposal, wishes turned into whiches.
I have you for breakfasts, you can have me for brunches;
Soon enough, the scarecrow will tear at the stitches.

So I just wonder what time and day is the last;
You take me to islands, but all the sails are half-mast.
Sometimes I wonder about the thought that goes into that,
So at the end of the day, I won't be harassed by aghast.

Leave Me Anyway

RENJ

I can see you laying down full of indifference,
Too taboo to talk, too weird to find reference.
Your room is mahogany, but it has two doors,
Carried by your family that made you do chores.

They talk by the podium, the lectern, the stand,
About how you unraveled the ribbons so grand.
When I hear you complain about wrappers over bags,
I remember in aisles to take note of the tags.

You're well-kept in a suit, your final hair stands.
Funny how they call it, when you're on your back, grand.
Your whole body's in a cushion and people knock;
Some others pull handkerchiefs until they can't hold back.

The elders argue which comes first to the scene:
The head or the feet—too long, it becomes obscene.
They heave for a lifetime; I'm quiet by the sidelines.
I wonder what it would be if I arrive at my decline.

You made me a promise: you'd come to my birthday,
But you had no right laying down on my day.
I treat the anniversary like a debutante's last;
I have my three-layer cake, but with onion ganache.

I can pretend that it's over and deep in the ground,
But I ask to myself if you can breathe around.
Sometimes I wonder if it would've been better in ashes,
But I think you'll come around more often in flashes.

At least ten cars drove you around that day:
Your mother in black, your sister in white, and I was in gray.
You're like a mirror in the middle of a grass field,
Reflecting red eyes and echoing voices stifled.

I can sleep on the couch and straighten up my posture,
Try to pretend that I'm you for the night's departure.
Maybe in faking it, it would be real by the next day—
What do I have to do so you won't leave me anyway?

Oxfords

RENJ

The soles of my Oxfords are worn-out;
The cuffs of my sleeves are clean all out.
They say life settles when one goes on the red,
While others say it's when cords are tied to bleed.
I can see you walking down the carpet onto me;
Your step front forces mine to step back—
The ladies of the left side all wear veils of black.
Hard mahogany slides like elevators or subways,
And so is the mind, a running bullet train of outways.
The golden kisses of the ceiling's chandelier
Suddenly turn into sirens and raging cavaliers.

I owe you flowers and cream-sweet nights,
But all I could muse on are petty fights.
They say it's better late than never,
Although fatal is the thought of being sorry forever.

They say it's a city boy thing, but I don't believe;
They say the polluted won't lay himself on relief.
Could it be fear of what's the face behind the veil,
Or is it the bloodshot thighs fighting the frail?
I don't know, maybe it truly is just my illusion,
Seeing your grand entrance like an intrusion.
The lampposts outside suddenly blare red and blue;
My jumpers all fade the same color, too.
As soon as the music faded into full orchestra,
A starter gun rang out to bolt for the door in balestra.

I owe myself a bouquet of insistence,
My placket a well-deserved resistance.
You will find what you long for one day;
I just won't waste my time for an unwritten play.

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